

Unit: How Difficult and How Much Should I Read?

詳細內容雙語對照 / Detailed Bilingual Content

Lead-in Questions / 導入問題

Please answer these questions: Do you know how quick an average reader reads? How do you choose your English reading materials? How often do you read?

請回答這些問題：你知道一個普通讀者的閱讀速度有多快嗎？你如何選擇你的英語閱讀材料？你多久閱讀一次？

Difficulty Level of Reading Materials / 閱讀材料的難易度

Reading or learning to read is hard work. When we read, we try to recognize words associated with pronunciation and meaning through letter and word knowledge, then we combine what we have with our own background knowledge and develop our own interpretation of what we read. Our brain processes various information at the same time. This is not an easy task for the first language learners, it is even harder for second or foreign language learners because of the limited learning time and environment. Second or foreign language learners inevitably face difficulty decoding (of words) frequently. In order to have a general reading comprehension, a vocabulary of 3,000 word families or 5,000 lexical items is needed, as this would cover 90-95% of any non-specialist text (Chiang, 2009). Below this threshold level, it is difficult for learners to use reading strategies (such as the commonly mentioned guessing the meaning of a particular word from the context) for decoding. According to Waring and Takaki (2003), even if a word is encountered more than 18 times in a text, there is only a 10-15% chance that a reader will be able to remember its meaning. This seems disappointing, doesn't it?

閱讀或學習閱讀是一項艱苦的工作。當我們閱讀時，我們試圖通過字母和單字知識來識別與發音和意義相關的字詞，然後將我們所擁有的與我們自己的背景知識相結合，並對我們所讀的內容發展出我們自己的解釋。我們的大腦同時處理各種信息。對於第一語言學習者來說，這不是一項簡單的任務，而對於第二語言或外語學習者來說，由於學習時間和環境的限制，這更是難上加難。第二語言或外語學習者不可避免地經常面臨解碼（字詞）的困難。為了獲得一般的閱讀理解能力，需要 3,000 個詞族或 5,000 個詞彙項目的詞彙量，因為這將覆蓋任何非專業文本的 90-95% (Chiang, 2009)。低於這個門檻水平，學習者很難使用閱讀策略（例如通常提到的根據上下文猜測特定單字的含義）進行解碼。根據 Waring 和 Takaki (2003 年) 的研究，即使一個單字在文本中出現超過 18 次，讀者也只有 10-15% 的機會能夠記住它的含義。這看起來令人失望，不是嗎？

Don't despair yet. The Extensive Reading Approach we learned in the previous unit seems to be a way out. We can expose ourselves to a lot of reading, in order to increase the encountering with the words in different texts and contexts. However, this kind of approach takes time, which many second language or foreign language learners do not have. Therefore, I am going to try to give some advice to save your time for reading.

先不要絕望。我們在上一單元中學習的泛讀方法似乎是一條出路。我們可以讓自已接觸大量的閱讀，以便在不同的文本和語境中增加與字詞相遇的機會。然而，這種方法需要時間，而許多第二語言或外語學習者並沒有時間。因此，我將嘗試提供一些建議，以節省您的閱讀時間。

Question: How difficult should I read? / 問題：我應該讀多難的書？

Research has shown that a vocabulary size of 9,000 word families plus proper nouns covers over 98% of various texts (Nation, 2006; 2014). Therefore, setting 9,000 word families as your long-term goal is reasonable. With this vocabulary size, you could probably read unsimplified texts without assistance (Nation, 2014). For your information, an educated native speaker of English has a vocabulary size of around 20,000 words. Native speakers increase their vocabulary at the rate of around 1,000 word families per year (Nation, 2014). From my own research and experience, an undergraduate student in a leading university in Taiwan has a vocabulary size of approximately 8,000-10,000 words. To read without too many unfamiliar words becoming a burden while reading, no more than 2% of the running words should be beyond your knowledge (Nation, 2014). In other words, only two words in a 100-word text should be unknown. That is, 10 words in a 500-word text which is about one A4 single spaced page. Reading from the first paragraph and the above information, we can say that in principle, 2%-5% of unknown words in a text is acceptable for it does not cause comprehension difficulties. So, reading difficult materials which is way beyond our level is not always good, we should know our own levels first and then evaluate the materials based on the 95%-98% principle.

研究表明，9,000 個詞族的詞彙量加上專有名詞可以覆蓋超過 98% 的各種文本 (Nation, 2006; 2014)。因此，將 9,000 個詞族設定為您的長期目標是合理的。有了這個詞彙量，您可能可以在沒有協助的情況下閱讀未經簡化的文本 (Nation, 2014)。供您參考，一個受過良好教育的英語母語者的詞彙量約為 20,000 個單字。母語者以每年大約 1,000 個詞族的速度增加他們的詞彙量 (Nation, 2014)。根據我自己的研究和經驗，台灣頂尖大學的大學生的詞彙量大約在 8,000-10,000 個單字左右。為了在閱讀時不讓陌生單字成為負擔，文本中超出您知識範圍的字詞不應超過連續字詞的 2% (Nation, 2014)。換句話說，在一個 100 字的文本中，只有兩個單字應該是未知的。也就是說，在一個大約為一頁 A4 單倍行距的 500 字文本中，有 10 個未知單字。從第一段和上述信息來看，我們可以在原則上說，文本中 2%-5% 的未知單字是可接受的，因為它不會造成理解困難。因此，閱讀遠遠超出我們水平的困難材料並不總是好事，我們應該先了解自己的水平，然後根據 95%-98% 的原則評估材料。

In addition, we generally select reading materials that are either slightly over our level or under our level, depending on the different purposes of learning. If the purpose is to build reading interest or confidence, or vocabulary review, then we can choose the materials that are slightly under our English level in order to increase the speed and fun of reading. If our reading purpose is to increase vocabulary size, then we would benefit more if we read materials that are slightly above our current level for they contain words we do not know yet (Chiang, 2018). Research also suggests that a combination of extensive reading and direct vocabulary instruction is a more efficient method for vocabulary expansion (Nation, 1997; Schmitt, 2000).

此外，我們通常會根據不同的學習目的，選擇略高於我們水平或低於我們水平的閱讀材料。如果目的是建立閱讀興趣或信心，或者進行詞彙複習，那麼我們可以選擇略低於我們英語水平的材料，以提高閱讀速度和樂趣。如果我們的閱讀目的是增加詞彙量，那麼如果我們閱讀略高於我們當前水平的材料，我們將受益更多，因為它們包含我們還不認識的單字 (Chiang, 2018)。研究還表明，泛讀與直接詞彙教學相結合是擴展詞彙量更有效的方法 (Nation, 1997; Schmitt, 2000)。

Question: How much should I read? / 問題：我應該閱讀多少？

Usually, when it comes to input for language learning, we would say the more the better. According to Nation (2014), a learner is assumed to meet a particular word 12 times before a learner can actually recognize the word, i.e. learn the word. This ‘twelve repetitions’ are “enough to allow the opportunity for several dictionary look-ups, several unassisted retrievals, and an opportunity to meet each word in a wide variety of contexts.” An average reader reads between 150-200 words per minute. Nation (2014) tried to use corpora data to work out how much reading a learner should read in terms of running word counts and reading time. He worked out that for a reader with a slower speed of 150 words per minute to increase from a vocabulary size of 2,000 to 3,000, s/he would need to read around 200,000 words, and it would probably take 33 minutes per week, which is 7 minutes per day. For a learner of 3,000 word vocabulary size, s/he would need to read 300,000 running words, and that will be about 50 minutes per week (10 minutes per day). Furthermore, from the 4,000 level on, the increase of the required reading amount would become 500,000 extra words per year, which would take a learner about 17 minutes per day to read. For a 7,000-level learner, over an hour a day, five days a week, 40 weeks of the year would need to be devoted to reading, according to Nation’s calculation. Therefore, my suggestion is to stay or at least maintain the minimum level of contact with English. That is, reading for 15-30 minutes a day. It is like doing exercise or playing the musical instrument, frequency of contact matters.

通常，當談到語言學習的輸入時，我們會說越多越好。根據

Nation (2014年) 的說法，一個學習者被假定要在遇見一個特定單字 12 次之後才能真正識別該單字，即學會該單字。這「十二次重複」是「足以讓讀者有機會進行幾次字典查詢、幾次無輔助檢索，以及在各種語境中遇到每個單字的機會。」一個普通讀者的閱讀速度在每分鐘 150-200 個單字之間。Nation (2014年) 試圖利用語料庫數據計算出學習者在運行詞數和閱讀時間方面應該閱讀多少。他計算出，對於一個閱讀速度較慢、每分鐘 150 字的讀者來說，要將詞彙量從 2,000 擴展到 3,000，他需要閱讀大約 200,000 字，這大約需要每週 33 分鐘，即每天 7 分鐘。對於一個擁有 3,000 字詞彙量的學習者來說，他需要閱讀 300,000 字，大約是每週 50 分鐘（每天 10 分鐘）。此外，從 4,000 級開始，所需閱讀量的增加將變為每年 500,000 個額外的字，這將需要學習者每天花大約 17 分鐘進行閱讀。對於一個 7,000 級的學習者來說，根據 Nation 的計算，一年中有 40 週、每週五天、每天需要花一個多小時進行閱讀。因此，我的建議是保持或至少維持與英語接觸的最低水平。也就是說，每天閱讀 15-30 分鐘。這就像做運動或彈奏樂器一樣，接觸的頻率至關重要。

Nation also pointed out an exciting result in one of his results. With his analysis of the corpora, it is better for learners to both read a lot (of magazines, newspapers and novels) and watch plenty of movies for vocabulary inclusion. Therefore, when you are tired of reading, watch a movie instead!!

Nation 還指出了一個令人興奮的結果。通過他對語料庫的分析，對於學習者來說，最好是既大量閱讀（雜誌、報紙和小說），又觀看大量的電影以擴展詞彙量。因此，當你讀累了，就看部電影吧！

Table 4: Word List Level and Reading Requirements / 表4：字詞等級與閱讀需求對照表

2nd 1000: 200,000 words | 33 mins/week (7 mins/day)

第二個1000字：200,000字 | 每週33分鐘（每天7分鐘）

3rd 1000: 300,000 words | 50 mins/week (10 mins/day)

第三個1000字：300,000字 | 每週50分鐘（每天10分鐘）

4th 1000: 500,000 words | 1 hr 23 mins/week (17 mins/day)

第四個1000字：500,000字 | 每週1小時23分鐘（每天17分鐘）

5th 1000: 1,000,000 words | 2 hrs 47 mins/week (33 mins/day)

第五個1000字 : 1,000,000字 | 每週2小時47分鐘 (每天33分鐘)

6th 1000: 1,500,000 words | 4 hrs 10 mins/week (50 mins/day)

第六個1000字 : 1,500,000字 | 每週4小時10分鐘 (每天50分鐘)

7th 1000: 2,000,000 words | 5 hrs 33 mins/week (1 hr 7 mins/day)

第七個1000字 : 2,000,000字 | 每週5小時33分鐘 (每天1小時7分鐘)

8th 1000: 2,500,000 words | 6 hrs 57 mins/week (1 hr 23 mins/day)

第八個1000字 : 2,500,000字 | 每週6小時57分鐘 (每天1小時23分鐘)

9th 1000: 3,000,000 words | 8 hrs 20 mins/week (1 hr 40 mins/day)

第九個1000字 : 3,000,000字 | 每週8小時20分鐘 (每天1小時40分鐘)